

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 36

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A young man, voting for the first time in a general election, is taken to the polling station by his ageing father.

1

My father woke me earlier than he needed to. The polling station, a primary school five streets away, would not open for another hour, but he had laid out my identity card on the kitchen table the night before, beside his own, and beside the polling card with my name printed in unfussy black letters. He had also, I noticed, polished his shoes. He had not polished his shoes for any wedding in living memory, but he had polished them for this.

2

We walked the long way round, past the coffee shop where he had once shown me how to read a newspaper, and past the bus stop where, many years ago, he had taught me to count my change. He did not speak much. Every so often he glanced at me sideways, as if checking that I was still there, as if I might at any moment dissolve into the boy I had been the last time we had walked this stretch together. The morning was cool and grey, and the road, usually noisy by this hour, lay strangely hushed beneath our feet.

3

He had voted in every election since he was twenty-three. He had voted in the rain, in the heat, once with a fever, and once, my mother liked to remind us, on the morning of her sister's funeral, because, he said, the dead would forgive him and the country would not. I had heard the story a hundred times. I had rolled my eyes at it a hundred times. This morning, walking beside him, I did not roll my eyes. I tried instead to imagine being twenty-three in a country that was only a few years older than I was, and casting, for the first time, a vote that no one in his family had ever been allowed to cast before.

4

At the gate of the school, a queue had already formed. Old men in collared shirts. Young mothers with babies in slings. A few of my own classmates, who nodded at me with the careful seriousness of people who have agreed, without saying so, to behave like adults for an hour. My father straightened his shirt.

He looked at me, and then, for the briefest moment, he looked at the ground, and I understood, with a small shock, that he was nervous on my behalf.

5

Inside, the hall smelled of floor wax and quiet effort. The officials, schoolteachers I half recognised, spoke in low, measured voices, as though loud speech might disturb something fragile. A woman checked my card against a printed list, drew a thin red line through my name, and handed me a folded ballot paper. The paper was lighter than I had expected. It seemed strange that something so thin could carry so much weight. My father, behind me, was being attended to by a colleague at the next table; I did not turn to look at him, but I knew he was watching.

6

The booth was a narrow cardboard cubicle with a stub of pencil tied to a string. I stood inside it and read the names on the ballot twice, although I had already decided. I made my mark. The pencil scratched against the paper with a small, ordinary sound — the same sound, I thought, that pencils have made in classrooms for a hundred years. I folded the paper as I had been told. I walked to the box. I posted it. The box made no noise at all, which surprised me; I had expected, foolishly, that there might be a click.

7

Outside, in the school courtyard, my father was waiting under a flame-of-the-forest tree. He did not ask me whom I had voted for. He never would. He only looked at me, and I looked at him, and after a moment he nodded — once, slowly, the way he had nodded the first time I had cycled to the end of the street and back without falling. We walked home a different way, past the market, which was beginning to wake. Neither of us said anything important. He bought two bowls of noodles from a stall, and we ate them standing up at the counter, because there were no seats, and because it did not occur to either of us, that morning, to want any.

8

Years later, when I stood at another booth in another election, with my own polished shoes and my own quiet nerves, I would understand what he had handed me that day. Not an opinion. Not a party. A habit. A weight. A small, stubborn duty that you carry, in the rain and in the heat, and on mornings when no one is watching, because someone, once, walked five streets with you, and showed you how.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator notices that his father has “polished his shoes.” Explain, in your own words, why this detail is significant. [2]

2. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 1 which shows that the father had prepared carefully for the morning. [1]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says his father glanced at him “as if I might at any moment dissolve into the boy I had been.” Explain what this comparison tells us about how the father sees his son on this particular morning. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The father once voted “on the morning of her sister’s funeral.” Explain, in your own words, what this story shows about the father’s attitude towards voting. [2]

5. The narrator says, “I had rolled my eyes at it a hundred times. This morning... I did not roll my eyes.” What does this change suggest about the narrator? [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator’s classmates nod at him “with the careful seriousness of people who have agreed, without saying so, to behave like adults for an hour.” Explain how this phrase captures the **mood** among the young voters. [2]

7. At the gate, the father “looked at the ground” briefly. What does this small action reveal about the father at this moment? [1]

From Paragraph 5

8. The narrator writes that the hall “smelled of floor wax and quiet effort.” Explain how the language used in Paragraph 5 creates an atmosphere of **seriousness**. Support your answer with **two** details. [3]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator says he had expected the box to make a “click.” What does this small expectation tell us about him? [1]

From Paragraph 7

10. The father nods at his son in the same way he had nodded “the first time I had cycled to the end of the street and back without falling.” Explain why this comparison is effective. [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final paragraph of the text? [2]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article asking whether universities still teach what employers actually need.

1

A quiet anxiety has settled over the modern graduate. She has done what her parents asked her to do: she has finished her degree, often at considerable cost, and she has emerged with a certificate that, a generation ago, would have been a passport to a decent salary and a serious job. Today, the certificate increasingly behaves like an entry ticket to a queue. Employers, surveyed year after year by bodies such as the World Economic Forum, complain that graduates arrive unable to write a clear paragraph, work in a team without supervision, or learn a new software tool without three weeks of training. The complaint is now so familiar that it has lost the power to shock.

2

The gap is widening for two related reasons. The first is the simple speed at which work itself is changing. Skills that were considered specialist in 2015 — basic data analysis, working with cloud-based tools, communicating in short, visual formats — are, in 2025, treated as baseline. Universities, which take years to design a course and longer to remove one, struggle to keep pace. The second reason is that the kinds of tasks employers most prize — judgement, attention, collaboration — are precisely the kinds of tasks that are hardest to assess by lecture, examination and essay.

3

Into this gap have rushed the so-called micro-credentials: short, focused courses, often online, that promise to teach a specific marketable skill in weeks rather than years. Google's career certificates, Coursera's specialisations, and a forest of coding bootcamps now make claims that universities, on average, cannot. They are cheaper. They are faster. They are designed in direct consultation with the firms that will eventually hire from them. A 2024 study by the OECD found that, in several technology sectors, employers rated a graduate of a six-month bootcamp as equally "job-ready" as a holder of a three-year degree, and in some sub-fields rated the bootcamp graduate more highly.

4

Yet to conclude from this that universities have failed, and ought to be replaced wholesale by bootcamps, is to confuse two quite different jobs. A bootcamp teaches you how to do today's work today. A university, at its best, teaches you how to think well enough to do tomorrow's work, including work that does not yet exist. The historian who learns to weigh evidence, the philosopher who learns to test an argument, the literature student who learns to read what is not said — none of them are training for a specific job, and that is precisely the point. The world will, sooner or later, demand of them a problem no syllabus could have predicted; what they will have is the long habit of thinking it through.

5

This is, admittedly, a hard case to make to a parent paying tuition, or to a student staring at an overdraft. It is also a case that universities themselves have weakened. Too many lectures still treat students as passive recipients. Too many essays test memory rather than judgement. Too many "useless" subjects — by which the public usually means the humanities — have allowed themselves to be defended only in terms of vague self-improvement, when their real defence is far sharper: they produce, reliably, the kinds of careful, supple minds that organisations beg for in their senior leaders, and almost never produce on their own.

6

Employers, for their part, are not blameless. Many complain about graduate readiness while continuing to advertise entry-level roles that demand five years of experience. Many cut their own training budgets and then express astonishment that new hires need training. Some have begun, sensibly, to act differ-

ently: companies such as IBM, Accenture and several Singaporean banks have moved away from degree requirements for whole categories of role, choosing instead to test directly for the skills they need. A small but growing number now run their own multi-year apprenticeships, paid from the start, that combine paid work with structured study.

7

Good reform, then, is unlikely to come from either side alone. It is likely to look like this: universities that hold firm on the slow, difficult work of thinking, but that build, alongside their degrees, shorter and more practical pathways stacked into the longer ones. Employers that stop using degrees as a lazy filter and start describing, honestly, what they will teach a new hire and what they expect the new hire to bring. Governments that fund both. Students, finally, who choose with their eyes open: not between a degree and a bootcamp, but between different combinations of the two, undertaken in different orders, across what will plainly be a working life of forty or fifty restless years.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that a degree now “behaves like an entry ticket to a queue.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the value of a degree today. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** reasons why universities are struggling to keep up with the modern workplace. [2]

From Paragraph 3

14. In Paragraph 3, what **three** advantages do micro-credentials and bootcamps have over universities? [2]

15. What does the OECD finding in Paragraph 3 reveal about employer attitudes towards bootcamp graduates? [1]

From Paragraph 4

16. The writer says that “a bootcamp teaches you how to do today’s work today. A university, at its best, teaches you how to think well enough to do tomorrow’s work.” Explain, in your own words, the contrast the writer is making. [2]

17. The writer gives the example of “the literature student who learns to read what is not said.” What is the writer suggesting about the value of such a skill? [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says that the humanities are too often defended in terms of “vague self-improvement.” What does the writer suggest is the **stronger** defence of these subjects? [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. Give **two** ways in which the writer suggests employers are partly to blame for the skills gap. [2]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer describes a working life of “forty or fifty restless years.” What does the word **restless** suggest about the future of work? [1]

21. What is the writer’s overall **tone** in Paragraph 7? [1]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why universities struggle to meet employer needs**, and **what good reform of higher education might look like**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2, 3, 5, 6 and 7** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Universities struggle to meet employer needs because ...

— END OF PAPER —